

England's social housing waiting-list outlook

What published register data suggests for 2026–2028, with a cautious planning view to 2030.

1,340,527	1,359,901	+1.4%
households on registers in 2025	central forecast for 2028	forecast change, 2025–2028

The central outlook

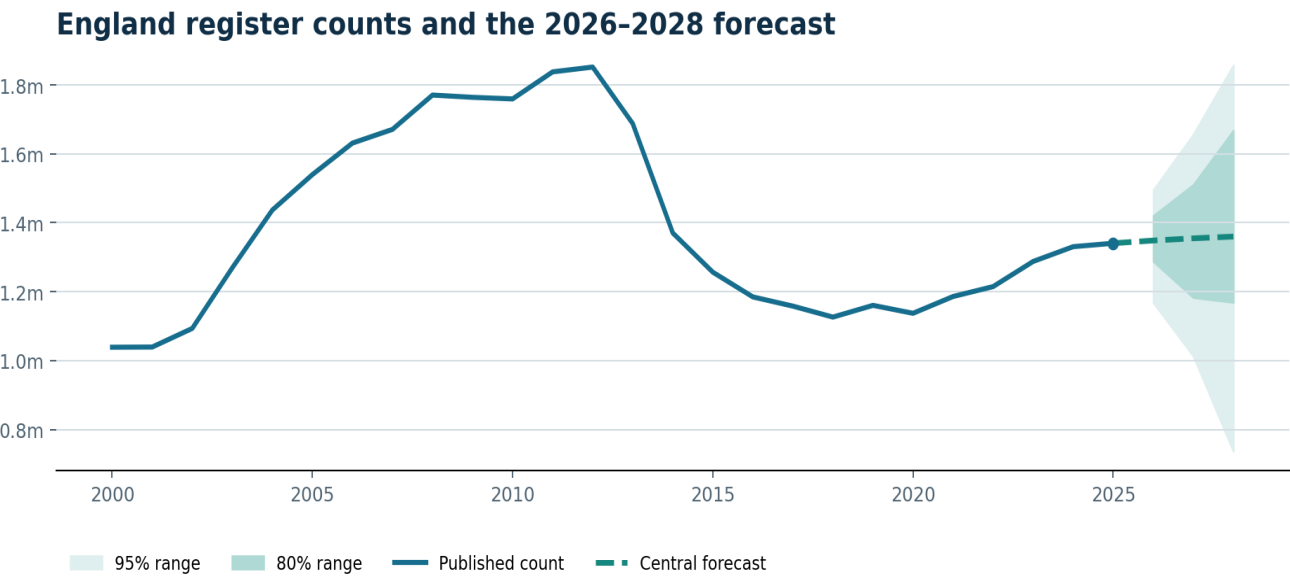
England's published social housing register count reached **1.34 million households in 2025**. The selected model points to a modest increase to about **1.36 million in 2028**. This is a broadly stable central path rather than evidence of a decisive rise or fall.

The uncertainty range is wide. For 2028, the empirical 80% range is approximately **1.17 million to 1.67 million**. Planning and public discussion should therefore focus on the range of plausible outcomes as well as the central estimate.

Source: Ministry of Housing, Communities and Local Government Live Table 600. Counts are households on local-authority housing registers at 1 April each year.

Waiting lists have moved in long cycles

The national series does not follow a simple straight line. It fell through much of the 1990s, rose strongly during the 2000s, peaked in 2012, then declined before increasing again after 2020.



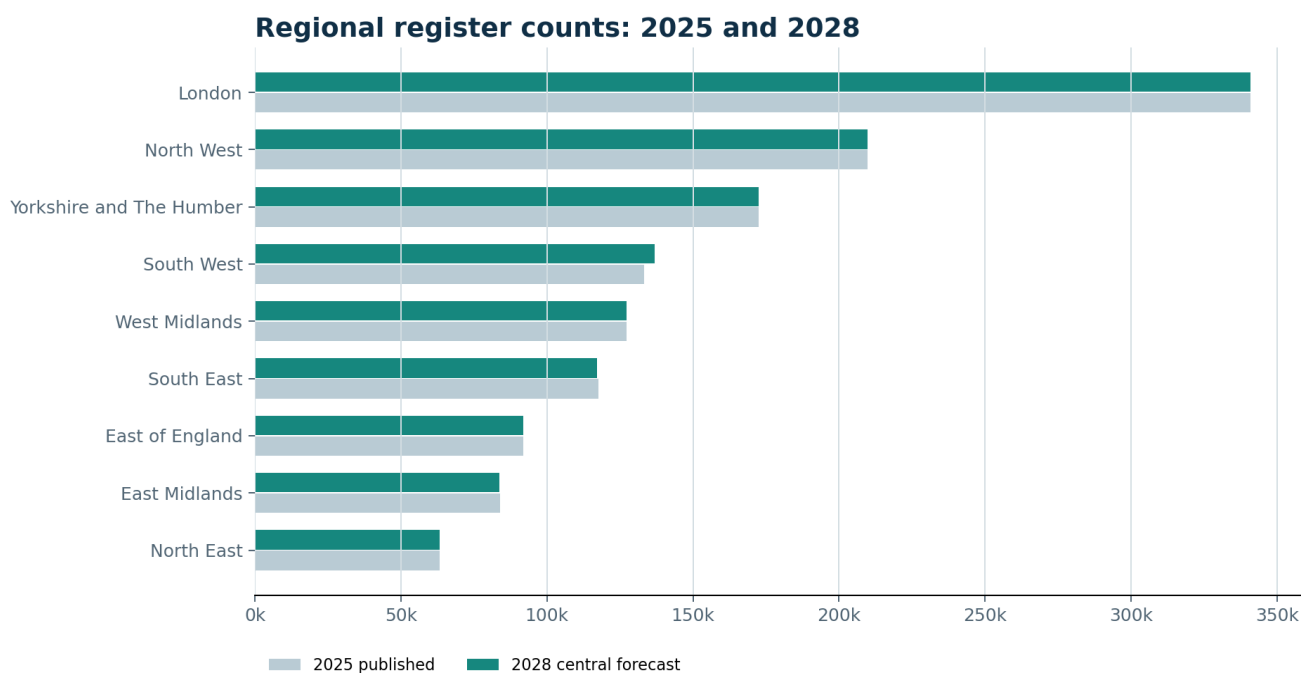
1.02m	1.85m	+17.9%
1998 series low	2012 series peak	increase from 2020 to 2025

Why this matters

Models that extend a fixed long-run trend can perform poorly when the underlying series has repeated turning points. The final forecast was therefore chosen through rolling historical tests rather than by selecting the model with the most visually compelling trajectory.

A varied picture across England

London remains the largest regional register count in the central forecast. Most regions are broadly stable over the three-year horizon, while the South West shows the clearest modelled increase.



Region	2025	2028 forecast	Change
London	341,009	341,009	+0.0%
North West	209,887	209,887	+0.0%
Yorkshire and The Humber	172,536	172,536	+0.0%
South West	133,231	136,877	+2.7%
West Midlands	127,179	127,179	+0.0%
South East	117,590	117,188	-0.3%
East of England	91,871	91,871	+0.0%
East Midlands	84,013	83,657	-0.4%
North East	63,211	63,211	+0.0%

A forecast is a range, not a promise

The central estimate summarises the model's expected path. The ranges show how far historical forecast errors have extended when the same method was tested on unseen years.

Year	Central estimate	80% range	95% range
2026	1,348,467	1,288,128–1,420,408	1,168,582–1,494,999
2027	1,354,819	1,183,078–1,510,443	1,013,012–1,656,568
2028	1,359,901	1,169,171–1,667,851	736,752–1,857,482

What the ranges show

Uncertainty widens with time. The 2026 estimate is relatively concentrated, while the 2028 range is much broader. Outcomes near either side of the range would not automatically mean the model had failed; they reflect the volatility seen in the historical record.

What they do not show

The ranges are based on historical model error. They cannot capture every possible policy change, administrative change or future shock. They should support scenario planning, not be read as exact probabilities for every future event.

Communication principle

Headlines should pair the central estimate with its uncertainty. Reporting only 1.36 million would give a false impression of precision.

Built for transparent public use

The analysis uses a reproducible pipeline from the published source file to the dashboard, forecast tables and briefing. The final national and regional results can be regenerated from the repository.

Evidence step	What was done
Source integrity	The retained Table 600 workbook, extracts and processed series were compared directly.
Reconciliation	The nine regions sum exactly to England in every year from 1987 to 2025.
Model testing	Seven transparent models were evaluated with expanding-window rolling-origin backtesting.
Selection	Mean absolute error was the primary measure because it is interpretable in households.
Uncertainty	80% and 95% empirical ranges were derived from out-of-sample historical errors.

How the findings can be used

The dashboard supports national and regional comparison, planning conversations and accessible communication of uncertainty. The forecast provides an evidence baseline against which new data and policy developments can be assessed.

Measure and interpretation

Table 600 counts households on local-authority housing registers. These registers are an important administrative measure of social housing waiting-list demand, but they are not a complete measure of housing need. Changes may reflect register management as well as changes in underlying demand.

Explore the interactive dashboard and full analytical report in the HAILIE waiting-list forecast repository.

Data source: MHCLG Live Table 600, retrieved 7 August 2026. Analysis covers 1987–2025; forecasts begin in 2026.